Ready to Rank

FOR AUSTRALIAN TRADE BUSINESSES

40 THINGS TO FIX SO CUSTOMERS ACTUALLY FIND YOU

Twenty you can fix yourself this week. Twenty that need someone who does this for a living. A plain English checklist for getting found on Google, in the map results, and in the answers people now get from ChatGPT.

readytorank.com.au
Melbourne local SEO

Current as at September 2026

Before you start

Work down this list with your phone in your hand, tick what passes and circle what does not (it is current as at September 2026, so if a menu named here does not match what you see, the idea still holds, the button has just moved). None of it buys you a position in Google and nobody can promise you one, because the weightings are not published and anyone quoting you a percentage for a ranking factor is guessing. What this list does is remove the reasons a homeowner, a search engine or an AI assistant cannot tell what you do, where you do it and how to reach you, and that part is inside your control.

The document is in two halves

Part one, items 1 to 20. Things you can check and fix yourself. Each one ends in a Check, which is how you tell in a few minutes whether you have passed.

Part two, items 21 to 40. The work that needs a professional or a developer. Each one ends in an Ask, which is the exact thing to put to them, and how you would know it has actually been done. You are not meant to do these yourself. You are meant to know they exist and know what to ask for.

The badges

5 min check it now on your phone. **30 min** sit down at a laptop. **Get help** it is a build job, not an edit.
Specialist, **Developer** and **Ask your SEO** tell you who to hand part two items to.

The quick checks

Five things you can prove on your phone before smoko.

01 Check Google actually holds your pages — 5 MIN

Every job here assumes Google can read your site. Sometimes it cannot. A noindex setting left on after the build, a coming soon mode, or a plugin blocking crawlers. Nothing tells you.

CHECK Type site:yourdomain.com.au into Google. Pages listed, tick this. Nothing, or only the home page, and something blocks Google. Fix that first. Then open yourdomain.com.au/robots.txt. Disallow: / on its own, or GPTBot, ClaudeBot or PerplexityBot under Disallow, locks those out. Ask if that was deliberate.

02 Read the blue line Google shows for your site — 5 MIN

The blue line on a search result is your page title. On plenty of trade sites it still says Home or Untitled. That line is one of the first things a customer reads.

CHECK Search your business name and read the blue line out loud, then read your browser tab. Do the same on your two main service pages. If any does not name your trade and your area, fix it under Page settings or SEO title.

03 Ask ChatGPT and Google about your own business — 5 MIN

These tools can only repeat what is published about you. They cannot invent a fact you have never put in writing. So ask them about yourself and read what comes back.

CHECK Open ChatGPT and type: who is [your business name] in [your suburb] and what do they do. Then: find me a [your trade] in [your suburb]. Run both in Google too. Write down what is wrong, what is missing, and whether you show up.

04 Fill in your own quote form and see where it lands — 5 MIN

Forms break quietly. The mailbox belonged to whoever built the site, or the plugin stopped sending after an update. Nothing errors, so enquiries stop and you blame the site.

CHECK On your mobile, fill in your own form: test, hot water unit, Reservoir. Check the inbox and the junk folder. Nothing in a few minutes means broken. Then ask whose inbox this is, and whether you keep it if you stop paying the builder.

05 Check the Google listing is yours, and the only one 5 MIN

Plenty of listings were set up by an agency or a mate, and you have never held the login. If it is not yours you cannot change the number. Duplicates split your reviews.

> CHECK Signed in to your Google account, search your business name. A panel with Edit profile means it is yours, tick this. Own this business means it is not: start the request today with your ABN. Then search Google Maps for duplicates, including old names and misspellings.

Get found locally

Your Google Business Profile, the listing people see in map results.

06 Make your primary category your trade, not contractor 5 MIN

The primary category is the shortest description of your business Google holds, and the one field that names your trade. Contractor, Handyman or Home improvement describe half the trades in your suburb.

> CHECK Edit profile, then Business category. The primary should read the word a customer would type: Plumber, Electrician, Roofing contractor, Landscaper. Add secondary categories only for work you genuinely take calls for, not work you would like one day.

07 Fill in the Services list, and check your address 30 MIN

Left blank, your category name is the only wording describing your work. Nothing can tell you do gas fitting if no page says gas fitting. An address nobody visits shows where you sleep.

> CHECK Edit profile, then Services: add the five jobs you get rung about most, in customers' words. Tap Location: if a street address shows publicly and nobody has come to it, switch it off and list suburbs under Service area. Google may ask you to verify again.

08 Ask for reviews the day you finish, and reply to every one 30 MIN

Reviews put words about real jobs in real suburbs online without you writing them. Asking the same afternoon beats asking a fortnight later. Never buy reviews, write your own, or trade a discount for one.

> CHECK Save your review link from Google Business Profile as a phone shortcut. If you cannot send it in ten seconds from the job, set that up tonight. Then count reviews with no reply and do five a night, one and two star first.

Say it plainly

Plain words anyone can repeat, including Google and AI assistants.

09 Say what you do and where in the first line — 5 MIN

Plenty of trade sites open with a slogan. A slogan states nothing. One plain sentence naming your trade, your suburb and who you work for fixes it. Use your regulator's words. Boring beats clever.

> **CHECK** Read your home page's first real sentence out loud. Does it name your trade and your area? Could you paste it onto another trade's site unchanged? If it fails either test, rewrite it. Words inside an image do not count.

10 Get your facts out of images, PDFs and quote forms — 5 MIN

A price list saved as a JPEG. A service area as a map picture. Prices behind an email form. Text inside an image is not text, so Google, AI assistants and customers cannot read it.

> **CHECK** Try to highlight the text with your finger. If you cannot select it, it is a picture and nothing can read it. Test any PDF you link to as well. Retype your prices or service areas onto the page as text.

11 Write the suburbs you cover, and say where you stop — 30 MIN

Vague service areas cost you calls from an hour away, and locals unsure you come to them. A map embed or postcode checker is not text. A page is matched only on what it says.

> **CHECK** Open your service area page, tap Find in page, type a suburb you worked this week. If nothing highlights, it is not on your site. Write your 10 to 20 suburbs as a sentence with the state, and say where you stop.

12 Put a real price range on every main job — 30 MIN

Cost is the first thing anyone asks, and nothing can repeat a figure that is not on your page. Contact us for a quote leaves you taking ballpark calls on the tools.

> **CHECK** Find in page and search for a dollar sign. If the only $ is in a review, you have no figure. Pick one true number per main job. Prices for homeowners include GST, so say so. Only promise warranties you will honour: consumer guarantees still apply.

13 Turn your five phone questions into five headings 30 MIN

You answer the same five questions every week. Written as headings with plain answers, they are there for customers and for the assistants people now ask, which repeat only what a page states.

> CHECK Write down your five most common questions. Search a few words from each with Find in page. If none appears as a heading, that content does not exist yet. Only answer what is right for your trade in your state, and say which state: rules differ.

14 Give every service its own page GET HELP

One Services page with ten bullets gives every job the same three words. Hot water repairs and switchboard upgrades need different pages answering different questions. A page is only quoted for what it explains.

> CHECK Count the separate pages you have for the work you do. One Services page with a list is one page. Do your three most profitable jobs have their own page, heading, explanation and photos? If not, this is a build job, so order three pages.

Prove you are legit

The facts that let someone look you up.

15 Put your licence number and ABN in every footer 30 MIN

You are asking a stranger into a house. Your ABN and licence number let a homeowner check you. State rules differ, and your website can count as advertising.

> CHECK Scroll the footer on three pages. All three carry your name, ABN and licence number? Confirm your ABN at abr.business.gov.au, your licence on your register: Victorian Building Authority, Energy Safe Victoria, NSW Fair Trading, QBCC, Electrical Safety Office. Is it current and in your name? Publish nothing you cannot prove.

16 Swap the stock photos for your crew and real jobs 30 MIN

Stock photos tell a homeowner nothing about who is turning up. Photos of you, your signed ute and real jobs are evidence. A photo carries no words, so caption it.

> CHECK Look at every photo on your home page and main service page. Could any of them be another business? If the ute has no signage, or the tradie is not your crew, replace it. Caption each with the job and suburb. Put five on your Google Business Profile.

17 One business name, one phone number, everywhere 30 MIN

Your name and number sit on directories, Facebook and old profiles. Where they disagree, some show a number you no longer answer, so the caller rings the next bloke.

> CHECK Read the business name and phone number out loud from your Google Business Profile, your website footer and your Facebook page. Any difference is the problem. Search your name in quotes and mark each listing right or wrong. Claim your free Apple Business Connect listing, and Bing Places.

Don't lose the job

Two about the call, one about who controls your site.

18 Make your phone number tappable text on every page 30 MIN

On many trade sites the number sits in the header graphic. A phone cannot dial a picture. Text in a tel: link opens the dialler in one tap. Every page needs one.

> CHECK Open your site on your mobile and tap the number in the header. Keypad up with your number in it passes. If not, press and hold: selectable text needs a link, a picture needs retyping. Check the footer and a service page too.

19 Say the hours you actually answer the phone 5 MIN

Templates come with 24/7 emergency service. Ring at 10pm, get voicemail and no call back, and you have shown you do not do what your site says. Publish only what you will do.

> CHECK Read your home and contact pages at 9pm Sunday as a stranger would. If they promise anything you would not answer, change the words. Check your Google Business Profile hours, set special hours for your state's public holidays, then ring your own voicemail and listen.

20 Write down who holds your domain, hosting and login GET HELP

A site a mate or cheap agency built is often registered and hosted in their name, on their card. When that ends, the site and email go dark with no warning.

> CHECK Write down who holds four things: domain, hosting, website login, Google Business Profile. Look the domain up at whois.auda.org.au: the registrant must be your business. Check the expiry and auto renew. Cannot fill all four in five minutes? You do not control your site yet.

02

PART TWO · ITEMS 21 TO 40

WHAT YOU'LL NEED A HAND WITH

Part one was yours to fix. This half is not, and that is fine: it is the work you would hire someone to do, the same way you would not let a customer rewire their own switchboard. Every item below gives you the exact words to say and a way to tell when it has actually been done. You do not need to understand the mechanics. You need to ask the right question and know what finished looks like.

SPECIALIST
An SEO does this. It is their day job.

DEVELOPER
Whoever builds and maintains your site.

ASK YOUR SEO
You can ask the question. They do the work.

Cover yourself first

The jobs that cost you most when they get skipped.

21 Get your accounts and your domain in your own name SPECIALIST

On most trade sites the old web person owns the domain, the Google listing and the tracking. Nothing else on this list can be done without that access.

ASK FOR Say: put me as owner on my domain, hosting, Google Business Profile, Search Console and Analytics, using my own email, and stay on as manager. Done when I get an owner invite for each and can log in without you.

22 Never rebuild the site without a redirect plan SPECIALIST

A rebuild changes every address. Old addresses that lead nowhere take their history with them, and the links pointing at them stop counting. This happens in a weekend.

ASK FOR Say: before we launch, give me a redirect map, every old address matched to the closest new page as a permanent 301, not all to the home page. Done when I paste three old addresses into my phone and each lands right.

23 Make sure nothing is telling Google to stay away DEVELOPER

A rebuild can leave a no index tag or a robots file blocking your whole site, or leave the test copy public, so there are two of everything. You cannot see either from the front.

ASK FOR Say: confirm my live site is not blocked, and that no test copy is public. Done when Search Console shows my main pages indexed, and searching my business name in quotes finds one site, not two.

24 Check whether your site has been hacked SPECIALIST

Search Console has a Security Issues report and a Manual Actions report, and neither gets opened on most trade sites. Injected spam pages can sit on a site for years without the owner seeing them.

ASK FOR Say: open both reports, show me what is in them, and scan my site for pages I never wrote. Done when I see both screens clean, or a written list of what is there and the cleanup plan.

25 Check your enquiry emails actually arrive DEVELOPER

A form can submit, show a thank you page and never reach you, because the domain sending the notification is not set up to be trusted. Most sites store nothing, so the job is gone.

> **ASK FOR** Say: set up SPF, DKIM and DMARC, the records that prove my domain sends the email, and save every enquiry inside the site as well. Done when I watch a test enquiry land on my own phone.

Under the bonnet

The plumbing of the site, where you cannot look.

26 Get every version of your address to one place DEVELOPER

Your site can answer on four addresses: with www, without, and each with and without the s in https. Left alone, Google picks one itself, and it may not be the one you sell from.

> **ASK FOR** Say: make all four versions of my address redirect to one, and set the canonical tag, the code naming the address I want used, to match. Done when I type each of the four into my phone and land on the same one.

27 Get the code that names your trade DEVELOPER

Your site can carry a block of code that names your trade, address, phone and hours in a form software reads. Most trade sites carry none, or a generic one the theme added.

> **ASK FOR** Say: add LocalBusiness schema, the code naming my business for software, using the exact type for my trade, Plumber, Electrician, RoofingContractor, HVACBusiness or GeneralContractor. Done when it passes both search.google.com/test/rich-results and validator.schema.org, since Google's test only reports what Google uses.

28 Order a full crawl for broken links and chains ASK YOUR SEO

Rebuilds leave dead links behind, and redirects that hop through two or three addresses before landing. Customers hit error pages you never see, and each extra hop risks losing what the link carried.

> **ASK FOR** Say: run a full crawl with Screaming Frog or Sitebulb and send me every broken link and every redirect chain, before and after fixing. Done when I hold both lists and the broken count is zero.

29 Ask what is making the first load slow DEVELOPER

Three things usually cause it: a slow server answering the first request, photos uploaded straight off a phone at full size, and scripts that must finish before anything appears on screen.

> **ASK FOR** Say: using the mobile Core Web Vitals report in Search Console, tell me my server response time, whether my photos are resized to a smaller format, and which scripts hold up the first view. Done when I get the same three after the fix.

Your Google listing

Maps, categories and reviews, done to Google's own rules.

30 Get your categories and Services list audited ASK YOUR SEO

Google names relevance, distance and prominence for local results, and your primary category is the first lever on relevance. Most tradies set it once and never looked again.

> **ASK FOR** Say: show me my primary and secondary categories beside the three businesses showing above me in my suburbs, recommend changes with a reason, and fill out the Services list inside my profile. Done when I read the before and after side by side.

31 Set up your service area the right way SPECIALIST

You work out of your house. Whether the address shows, how the suburbs are drawn, and what Google's guidelines allow for a business that travels all decide whether the listing stands.

> **ASK FOR** Say: set my listing up as a service area business under Google's own guidelines, hide my home address if it should be hidden, and set the suburbs I actually travel to. Done when I see the listing with no address and my suburbs listed.

32 Find out who else is editing your listing SPECIALIST

Anyone can suggest an edit to your Google listing, and competitors and data feeds do. Your hours, map pin or category change without a word, or an old duplicate gets merged over you.

> **ASK FOR** Say: check my profile for Google's own updates and suggested edits, find and remove any duplicate listings, and tell me who else has access. Done when there is one live listing with my details and email alerts switched on.

33 Get a review system that stays legal SPECIALIST

Google's own policy prohibits incentivised reviews, and the ACCC treats fake or misleading reviews as a breach of Australian Consumer Law. The wording of the request matters as much as the timing.

> **ASK FOR** Say: give me the review flow in writing, the exact wording of the request, when it fires off my job software, who answers a bad one, and confirm nothing is paid for or screened. Done when I approve that wording.

Pages and links

What gets written, and who points at you.

34 Get a page plan, not a keyword list ASK YOUR SEO

A keyword list is not a plan. The work is deciding which page answers which search, so one page owns hot water repairs and another owns blocked drains.

> **ASK FOR** Say: give me a keyword to page map, one row per page, the search it targets, and whether that searcher wants to book, compare or just read. Done when every row names a real page address on my site.

35 Make every suburb page earn its place SPECIALIST

Spinning up one page per suburb with the name swapped is a thin doorway page. Google's own spam policies name scaled content abuse and doorways, so this can backfire.

> **ASK FOR** Say: show me how each suburb page will differ, a real job I did there, local rules, travel and callout detail. Done when I read two of them side by side and can tell which suburb is which.

36 Make yourself one business across the web SPECIALIST

Software and search engines work from what the web already publishes about you. If your trade, name and suburb read differently across directories and association pages, there is no single version to repeat.

> **ASK FOR** Say: give me an entity audit, every page on the web that names my business, what each one says, and which ones disagree. Then fix or chase them. Done when I hold that list with a result against each line.

37 Get a real audit of who links to you ASK YOUR SEO

Anyone can point links at your site, including a cheap agency you sacked years ago. Those links stay attached to your domain, not theirs, and you cannot see them from the outside.

> **ASK FOR** Say: pull my backlinks, the sites pointing at mine, from the Search Console Links report, which shows a sample only, plus Ahrefs or Semrush. Done when I hold one sheet marked keep, watch or remove, and bought or earned.

Proof and paperwork

Numbers you can read, terms you can hold.

38 Get Analytics counting enquiries, not visits DEVELOPER

Most trade sites count page views, not enquiries. Google Analytics 4 calls a tracked action a key event, someone has to define yours, and it only counts from the day it is set up.

> **ASK FOR** Say: set up Google Analytics 4 so every form sent and every tap on a phone number fires its own key event, carrying the page it happened on. Done when one month later I read taps and forms split by page, not sessions.

39 Get Search Console set up in your name ASK YOUR SEO

Search Console is Google's own report on your site, and it is free. Set up on one version of your address it misses the rest. It also lists pages Google chose not to index.

> **ASK FOR** Say: set Search Console up as a domain property, verified through my domain settings, covering every version of my address, link it to Analytics, and show me the Pages report. Done when I hold the not indexed list with Google's reason against each.

40 Get the scope, reporting and exit terms in writing ASK YOUR SEO

The cheap monthly deal that reports rankings and does nothing is your real alternative. What gets done, who does it, what lands each month and what happens if nothing moves belongs on paper.

> **ASK FOR** Say: put the monthly work, the report I get, and the exit terms in the proposal. If I leave, I keep the domain, the accounts, the pages written and the tracking. Done when I read it before I sign, not after.

What your ticks mean

Count your ticks. There is no pass mark on this and any number we gave you would be made up, so the useful column is the other one: every item you circled is a reason a customer, Google or an AI assistant cannot work out what you do, where you do it or how to reach you. Work from the top down, because the five minute jobs are up there for a reason.

Not sure what to fix first?

One thing to start on Monday whether you ring us or not: ask every caller how they found you and write it down. After a month you can see whether the jobs are coming off Google, off your listing, off a mate, or off the lead reseller you resent paying, and you can stop guessing about what to keep paying for. If you circled more than a couple of these, or anything marked Get help, that is what the free discovery call is for: 45 minutes on Zoom where we go through your site and your listings with you and tell you what is worth fixing first and what you can leave alone. No jargon and no promises about rankings. Book it at readytorank.com.au, email hello@readytorank.com.au, or ring Jose on 0407 368 652.

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